Micro-decisions

Notice, interpret and respond in the moment

Use micro-decisions to make teaching responsive while the lesson is unfolding. Notice a useful signal, interpret its likely cause and choose a proportionate next action.

How to do it well

1 Notice. Attend to responses, work, hesitation, explanation quality and participation. Deliberately look for pupils whose thinking is not yet visible.

2 Interpret. Decide whether the evidence shows a task problem, a process gap, insecure prior knowledge, a misconception or a self-regulation barrier.

3 Respond. Probe, continue, slow down, re-model, reteach, change the participation structure, alter support or increase challenge according to the diagnosis.

4 Check. Sample understanding again. A micro-decision is incomplete until there is evidence that the action closed the intended gap.

What this sounds like

“I can see correct answers, but the explanations use different rules. I will ask for the reasoning before deciding whether we are ready to continue.”

Classroom example. A correct board response is accompanied by an incorrect explanation. The teacher probes the decision, notices the same pattern elsewhere and models the crucial distinction. A fresh check tests whether the reasoning changed. The small instructional adjustment follows evidence rather than the planned pace or the reassuring appearance of correct answers.

Top tips that make the technique work

Know what you are looking for. A planned misconception or key decision makes observation more useful than a general scan for engagement.

Probe before changing course. A correct answer may need reasoning; a wrong answer may be a slip rather than a shared misconception.

Find the missing thinking. Ask whose response is absent before judging the whole class from the visible few.

Make the smallest effective change. A cue, shorter step or clearer representation may be sufficient without restarting the lesson.

Check whether it landed. The next response should test the issue that prompted the adjustment.

Do and avoid

Do	Avoid
Link the action to an observed pattern.	Changing course because of one unrepresentative response.
Recheck the affected learning.	Persisting with the plan despite a clear common gap.

Further reading

Practitioner guidance; teacher language above is an illustrative BSCS adaptation.

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